

BELIEF IN THE HEREAFTER

INTRODUCTION

Belief in the Hereafter is one of the most important tenets of Islam. It occupies the central position in the preaching mission of prophets. It is on the foundation of this belief that the pillars of *shari'ah*, virtue and righteousness stand. Prophethood is also based on it. A *nabi* (prophet) is a *nabi* because he actually foretells this *al-naba' al-azim* (the great news). A *rasul* (messenger) is a *rasul* because he brings the message of its advent. John (sws) and Jesus (sws), Moses (sws) and Abraham (sws) all have proclaimed it. The Torah tacitly refers to it and the Psalms clearly mention it. In the Gospel, Jesus (sws) has warned that on the Day of Judgement only those people will enter the Kingdom of Heaven who will please his heavenly father. The Qur'an is a bearer of warnings and glad tidings for this Day.

The Qur'an says that it is man's own nature, his quest for justice and his awareness of good and evil that requires the coming of a Day of Judgement. If God is just and fair, then such a day must come. His providence, mercy, power and wisdom as well as His laws and practices all entail that man face a day of accountability. Without belief in such a day, religion is mere wishful thinking. The concepts of virtue, piety, justice, reward and punishment become baseless. Without such a day, the universe has no purpose and can only be regarded as the playground of divine forces.

I. THE TESTIMONIES

The first thing is man's awareness of good and evil. It is because of this awareness that his chiding conscience rebukes him on every evil. It is a small court of justice which is found within every person which delivers its unbiased verdict at all times. Whether he accepts it or not, a person is able to clearly listen to this verdict after every blemish that emanates in his thoughts and deeds; this continues until he becomes so deeply involved in evil that this evil completely surrounds his faculties thereby lulling the calls of his conscience to sleep.

The second thing is the nature of man by virtue of which he likes justice and dislikes injustice. No doubt, in spite of this dislike he still perpetrates injustice but this is not because he is not able to distinguish justice from injustice or that he likes the latter – it is because he loses his balance and poise by being overcome with desires and emotions.

The third thing is the incompleteness found both in man and in this world. From whatever aspect these two are seen, it is clearly evident that in every single part of theirs the great power and wisdom of their maker is apparent. In everything great meaningfulness, matchless order and sequence, unrivalled mathematical perfection and symmetry, extra-ordinary thoroughness and immense beauty of creativity astounds one's intellect. On the other hand, if one tries to understand both of them in their totality, one sees great incompleteness and lack of purpose in them.

The fourth thing is the attributes of God the effects of which are evident in every speck of this universe. The attributes of providence and mercy in particular need one's attention. After witnessing the extra-ordinary arrangement made by the Lord of this world to nurture and nourish man, how can a person of intellect think that his Lord will leave him unaccountable and how can it be expected from the merciful and gracious God to not punish people who have made this world a place of oppression and injustice.

The fifth thing is the manifestation of God's judgement in this very world. It took place through prophets who were elevated to the status of messengers. The Almighty blessed them with extra-ordinary miracles, helped them through Gabriel and before the actual Day of Judgement set up through these messengers miniature Days of Judgement on this earth. The objective was to prove the existence of God and the Hereafter before the people in the very manner scientific facts are proven through empirical evidence in a laboratory.